

Lecture 11

11.1 Topic Selection

Good morning. I think we are still waiting for a few students to come, and I'll get your second essay off here in a moment. We'll talk about the third essay today. So, bad news — you will submit your third essay next week. The good news — it's your final homework, so once you turn in the third essay, there is no more work at all for this course. We are finished except for the final exam, which is December 29th, so you have plenty of time to prepare for that.

Also, what we'll do next week — we'll talk about the final exam, and I'll show you some previous years' questions as long as you promise not to put them on 小红书 and get me in trouble like a student did last year. And we'll practice outlining and thinking of topics and problems and things like that the week after that. 😊

So after next week we're done. There's no more taught material, there's no more required work. Of course, you do not have to come to class — I won't check attendance — there's no more class readings or anything. But if you want to, you can come in Week 14 and we will practice the final exam. So we'll have a practice exam — I'll put up some questions, give you one hour, you've got pen and paper, and you try to write a short essay in one hour.

I recommend doing that. I think it's a good idea. If it's something you've done a lot before, if you're good at taking tests by hand, maybe you already know how that goes, but if you haven't done it before, I think it's a great idea to practice because you might discover something about time management or how long you can write for — for that kind of thing — and then you can fix that problem before the real final exam. You don't want to discover your problem the first time in the real final exam, so I recommend coming to the practice.

Weeks 15 and 16 — those will just be Q&A sessions and getting back your third essay, for example. So you can show up and get your essay, and if you have questions, you can stay and ask me; if you don't, just go. We'll cover everything about the third essay right now, and if you've got any questions, do let me know.

Three important key things I suppose that I should really stress:

- **① Make sure you pick an example essay.**

The third essay is an argumentative essay. The first two essays are persuasive essays — right? — so you are constructing a case. This is an argumentative essay, so you are deconstructing a case. So you must pick an essay and then disagree.

No matter how many times I say this, there will always be a few students who pick a class reading to disagree with, okay? That's kind of cheating because we've talked about it in class, you know the essay well, we've disagreed with it in class and all that stuff, right? So don't choose a class reading. That will get your grade really low. Make sure you pick an example essay — don't be the student who picks the class reading.

- **② Make sure you're giving the author's surname.**

I know this sounds like a trivial thing. Just please make sure you're giving the author's surname, not the author's first name. I know that doesn't sound that big, but it really drives me crazy. It sounds so weird, right? Like the author of this essay's name is Peter Harris. And students will write the essay and say "Peter says this" and "Peter says that," and I know — Harris says this and Harris says that. Okay — you're not his friend. Call him Harris. Obviously, the first time you use the name: "Peter Harris wrote the

essay *Backwards Britain*". In the essay, "Harris argues..." "He also argues...", right? The first time, use his full name. Every time after that, give his family name — his surname.

- **③ Write for a new reader.**

I mean, imagine the person who is going to read your essay has not read the original essay. I obviously have read these essays, but imagine that the person you're writing for hasn't. So make it clear what the arguments are before you disagree with them. If you just write arguments against them but you don't tell me what the arguments are, it seems very confusing. So make sure you say: "Harris argues *X*. His main argument is *X*. Here is why I disagree." Spell out the arguments like you would with a concession before giving a rebuttal. If you just give a rebuttal, it's not very clear — give the concession, then the rebuttal.

- **④ It is a 5–7 paragraph essay that you should write.**

It's totally up to you how you structure the essay. Obviously, paragraph one should be the introduction — introduce the essay that you're disagreeing with in the introduction, and the author. And the final paragraph should be the conclusion. But all the other stuff in between, you can structure however you like. So this is more like the second essay — you decide yourself how to structure, what devices to use.

Anyway, just to quickly introduce the example essays here. So, this one is *Backwards Britain: Why It's Time to Abolish the Monarchy* by Peter Harris. You guys know the meaning of monarchy. Can you tell me any other country that has a monarchy? Japan has a monarchy too — good. So it means having a king or a queen or an emperor or an empress. So this guy, an American political science professor at Colorado State University, argues that "as Britains ponder what sort of future they want for their country, they would do well to consider abolishing this corrosive and anachronistic institution." So he says — get rid of the British monarchy.

I don't see many students choosing that essay, and when they do, they often like to ask me, "Teacher, how do you feel about the monarchy?" I think students worry that I will be angry if they argue about the British monarchy. 🙄 Trust me — I won't. I promise I don't mind. I'm pretty on the fence about the monarchy. I don't have strong feelings for it, I don't have strong feelings against it, so please feel free to choose this topic. Otherwise I wouldn't have put it in the example essays if I felt upset about that topic. I do know people — like my own brother — who hate the monarchy and are very against it, and my own grandmother who loved the monarchy. It is a divisive issue in the UK, but personally I'm not strongly attached to it. So please feel free to pick that topic. 😊 Mainly, his arguments are values, right? He's giving arguments about equality, but he also talks about impacts later on.

You can choose *Cars Are Killing Us* by George Monbiot. And he's a journalist. The essay is quite interesting — he argues that we should cut the use of cars by 90 percent in the next 10 years. So that's his argument. It kind of reads a bit like a cost-benefit analysis — you know, he's giving the upsides and downsides — but I would say this essay is fairly simple, and I get a lot of students who pick this essay and they just argue that cars are good, right? The author says cars are bad, however I think cars are good. If you do that, you will get a **B+**, at best, okay? So what I'm saying is if you pick this essay, try and be a bit more creative — don't just argue that cars are good — maybe give a comparison or a prediction or something else.

There are three from the *New York Times* in these example essays. *Choose Leaders at Random*, by Adam Grant, he argues that America should get rid of elections and instead have something called **sortition**. I don't know if you've ever heard of it, but he says it was invented by the ancient Greeks. Sortition basically means instead of voting for someone, you just randomly pick someone. It's like a lottery. You know a lottery — you have a number, the computer chooses the number, if that's your number, you become the president, you become the mayor, you become the senator, right? So this is a completely different approach to politics. Could you call it democracy? I'm not sure. But he says we should randomly choose leaders. And I think his arguments mainly

are based on psychology — he talks about the psychology of power. He says people who want power are usually not the best people, and if you pick random people, you will get better leaders that way.

This article *Time to End Duty Free* is by *The Economist*, right? There are two by *The Economist*, and *The Economist* doesn't publish the name of the author. So when you — or if you — pick this one, you just need to say "The Economist argues *X*", "The Economist argues *Y*." You are disagreeing with *The Economist*. I have had students who chose this essay before and they must have done a lot of research, because they gave a name for the author. You don't need to do that, okay — you don't need to go researching who wrote the article — just say *The Economist* wrote the article.

You all know **duty-free**, I think you've probably bought duty-free before at the airport — 免税, right. Duty-free means you don't pay tax. Usually that means luxury items — perfume, tobacco, alcohol — those types of products. This author argues that we must end duty-free. So abolish duty-free — no tax-free shopping at airports. The article's arguments are mainly values, right? It's unfair. Why should rich people who fly to other countries not pay tax? It doesn't seem fair.

This essay *The Minimum Voting Age Should Be Zero*. Remember the essay *Where Are They*, he analyzes the different possibilities? He kind of uses the same logic here. He says: why should we not let someone vote, or why do we not let children vote? Is it mental capacity? No — we let mentally disabled people vote. Is it physical — they can't pull the lever? No — we let physically disabled people vote as well. So why not let children vote? And then he gives some impacts as well. So it's kind of that abductive reasoning in this essay too. So yeah, he's arguing that you should be able to take your six-month-old baby and let them vote, right? So there should be no limit to voting age. Currently, the voting age is 18 in the United States. I'll just say another thing — I should have deleted this — but Ezekiel Kweku is not the author, he is the editor. So the actual author is this guy Lyman Stone. So make sure you're disagreeing with Stone, not Kweku, if you choose this essay.

Here's to Your Health. I really put this one in the example essays as a good example of using comparative reasoning. I don't see many students choosing this one to disagree with and that's fine. She's just arguing that alcohol is bad for your health, and I think it's hard to argue alcohol is good for your health. But you can, if you want — I mean, take a challenge and try and disagree with this one — that's fine.

In Defense of Prejudice. The author here — if you look at the link — you can see his name there: Jonathan Rauch. So that's the author's name. He argues that we should not try to ban prejudice like racism, sexism, homophobia. The author himself is Jewish and gay, which is quite interesting because he's the kind of person who would normally be the victim of hate speech and prejudice.

It's important in the third essay that you identify the **main argument** the author is making, right? So here he makes maybe six arguments, but you have to figure out: which argument do I disagree with? Because you cannot disagree with every argument. And I think in this essay, yeah, his main argument is about *science*, right? That's the big one. So if you're going to disagree with this essay, you must address the topic of: "Does allowing people to be prejudiced benefit scientific research?" That's his main argument.

Hannah Riley — *Let People Have Cell Phones in Prison*. So she argues that if you go to jail, you should be allowed to bring your phone, call your family, play games while you're in prison. It's quite an interesting idea. What is the purpose of justice? What is the purpose of prison? Why do we send people to prison? To punish them — to make them suffer for the crime they have committed, right? What does she think is the purpose of sending people to prison? She thinks it's to make them better people — to rehabilitate them. So I think you should think about it in this way: two different versions of justice — one is about helping people become better, and one is about making people suffer. So she's arguing we should make people better. That's all I'll say — I won't give you too much help.

Usually if someone is a medical student, they will almost always choose this essay: *Let People Sell Their Kidneys*, and this is also by the *New York Times*. So he argues that, you should be allowed to sell one of your kidneys to someone who needs a kidney. The author, Dylan Walsh — in his hook, he points out that he himself received a kidney from his own father that saved his life. Be careful, because I often catch students who didn't read the essay. They will ask DeepSeek: "How can I disagree with selling kidneys?" And DeepSeek will say, "Well, if you let people sell their kidneys, then there will be a free market, and a free market in human organs is very harmful." But if you read the essay, **he does not argue for a free market**. He says the government should heavily regulate this. So be careful — take account of his framing. He is not saying just let people sell their kidneys on 淘宝 or something, right? He's saying let them go through a government process.

And I brought this one up a couple of weeks ago when we talked about Keen's essay — David Graeber, *On the Phenomenon of Bullshit Jobs*. And I'll just say: there's nothing wrong with the word "bullshit". I'm not saying it's a polite word, but students often don't like to say "bullshit". It's a pretty common word in English — we can say it on television. Donald Trump says "bullshit" all the time, okay? It's not really that bad a word. So it's fine. He argues that we could all work 15 hours a week, but we have created meaningless jobs to fill our time, and we don't need them, and it's really bad. So I would recommend, if you disagree with this guy, you really need to think about economics, right — what's the economic argument against him?

The Economist, again — you can just say *The Economist* says *Prostitution: A Personal Choice*. The main idea is in the sub-headline: "The Internet is making the buying and selling of sex easier and safer. Government should stop trying to ban it." So legalize prostitution is what it says. Just be careful — I get a lot of students who disagree by arguing that prostitution is bad, okay? And the essay is **not** saying prostitution is good. It is saying that it would be less harmful if it was legal, okay? So if you write an essay saying prostitution is bad, I would say: yes, so does *The Economist*, right. But it's arguing that by legalizing it, we would reduce the harm.

The United States Doesn't Spend Enough on Its Military. This author argues that the longer we go without increasing military expenditure, the more dangerous the world is likely to become. So he argues that thanks to America being so powerful and so strong, the world is peaceful, and America needs to keep spending more to keep the world peaceful. Thank you, America.

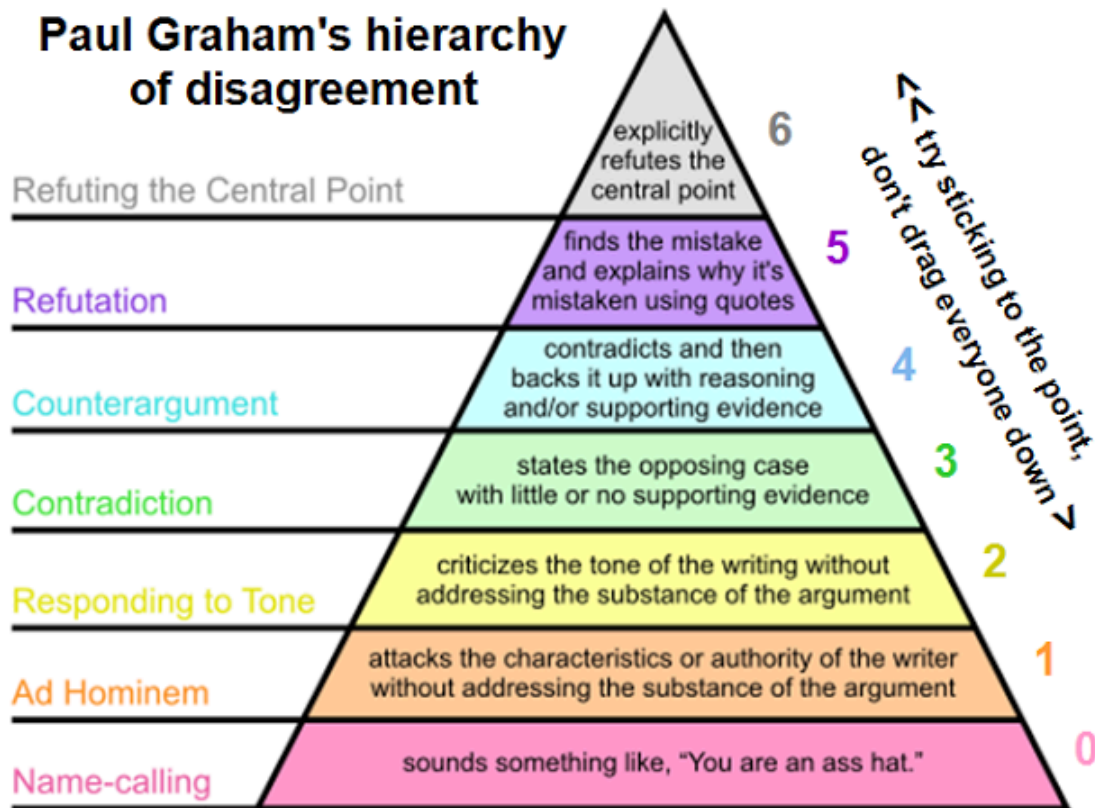
I get a lot of students who disagree with this essay, and they argue something like: "look at Iraq, look at Afghanistan." I don't think that's really a strong way to disagree with him here. Those are just small examples, but he's looking at the bigger picture, there hasn't been a world war since 1945, right? Can you think of other ways that we could keep the peace instead of having a super-powerful America?

And finally, this guy — Stephen E. Landsberg — he's a professor of economics, and he argues that environmentalism is like being in a cult. Are you familiar with the term "cult"? It's like 邪教 in Chinese. So he says economists like him are rational and environmentalists are irrational, like religious believers, and they are wrong. It's kind of a comparative essay.

So like I say, you can pick any of them, whichever topic you like or feel strongly about, for whatever reason, and write a five to seven paragraph argumentative essay disagreeing with the author. Do pay attention to these things.

11.2 How Do You Disagree

How do you disagree?



Well, in the playground you might call the person an idiot. You might say, "my opponent is an idiot" or "I don't like the way you sound" or "what a stupid man". Don't do that. If you can refute the central point, that's the best way to do it.

How do you identify the central point the author is making? **Try to draw a syllogism** — we've done this many times — but if you can draw up the whole essay in one syllogism, taking account of the main argument, and then say why that is wrong, you are disagreeing with — or you are refuting — the central point of the essay.

I've said it this way before: **internal** is when you say "opening borders would not boost the economy." You're saying the author's claim is wrong, right — and you've identified the main point and you're saying it is wrong. **External** is when you say "opening borders would have many other problems that the author doesn't talk about — what about crime and public health?" So think about external as concessions that the author didn't give, and think about internal as being the author's claims are not strong or something is wrong with the claim.

Consider the following syllogism:

- ① Treating people differently based on nationality is morally wrong.
- ② Borders force us to treat people differently based on nationality.
- **Conclusion:** We should abolish borders.

If I say "treating people differently based on nationality is morally wrong", could you disagree with that? No. If I say "borders force us to treat people differently based on nationality", could you disagree with that? Hard to do. If I say "we should abolish borders because of this", could you disagree with that? Yeah, absolutely. Many things are morally wrong, but that doesn't mean we should get rid of them, okay? And if you do it that way, you're kind of doing both — you're disagreeing with his logic, but you're also saying there are other things that would be problems as well. That's fine if you can do both.

Consider the following syllogism:

- ① Advancing technology causes unemployment.
- ② Technology and wealth will continue to advance rapidly in the future.
- **Conclusion:** In the future we will all be unemployed.

Keynes argues that advancing technology causes unemployment, could you disagree with that? He says: Don't worry about the Great Depression, the real problem is that we are too good, we are too successful. Our productivity has gone up so much that we don't know what to do with all the workers. Could you say he's wrong? Absolutely — I think many economists would disagree with him and say that is not what the Great Depression was about — it was much worse than that. "Technology and wealth will continue to advance rapidly in the future." — He was right but you could disagree — "and therefore we will all be unemployed in future".

Here's an example structure:

1. introduction
2. Differences between military training and media
3. The role of easily available guns in the United States
4. An example of countries with similar media violence and no shootings
5. How America can improve its violence rate

Like I said, you can do anything you like, you can use all different essay devices. Don't feel constrained in this essay. So, if I chose *Teaching Kids to Kill*, my main argument would be focusing on the differences between military training and media violence. The author's case rests heavily on three big comparisons between military violence and media violence. "However, he says this, but there are these big differences... He says that, but there are these big differences..."

And then I could give an external disagreement. I could say the real problem that he never addresses in America is that there are so many guns and people have access to guns. And then I can give a comparison, right? Look at Germany, which has many violent media but zero school shootings, compared to America, which had, last year, you know, 112 school shootings, right? So if violent media was the problem, then we should see it in other countries too. We only see it in America. Therefore, the problem is not violent media. The real problem is guns. And then in my conclusion, I can give some further analysis: what can America do to solve this violence problem?

Here's another example structure:

1. Introduction
2. The economic value of foreign languages
3. A comparison between the UK and Holland
4. The role of universities in shaping citizens, not workers
5. Further analysis on types of language policies at universities
6. Summarize the debate around learning foreign languages

If I want to disagree with *Kill the Language Requirement*, I think it's obvious the main argument would be the economic value of foreign languages. The author says, of all the people you know—all the successful people you know—how many of them speak these or any foreign languages regularly? Well, there are many, many people I can think of who are very successful and speak foreign languages, right? Maybe a comparison

between Britain, where like 30% of people can speak a foreign language, and Holland, where it's like 90% of people can speak a foreign language, and show how Holland has a better business environment thanks to foreign language.

Anyway, like I said, don't just think about counter-argument and disagreement. Think about comparisons and examples to demonstrate those things as well. So that's pretty much it. Does anyone have questions about the third essay? All clear? All right, try and practice disagreement here.

So, two syllogisms:

- Killing is morally wrong. Abortion is killing a human, and therefore abortion should be illegal.
- We should allow people to marry anyone they consent to marry. If two people want to get married and they're both over 18, then we should allow them to marry each other, right? And yeah, people can consent to polygamous marriage—three people. Therefore, we should legalize polygamy.

So pick one of those and then try and give one internal disagreement where you say the syllogism is actually wrong, and one external disagreement where you say there's something else we should consider. I'll give you five minutes, talk to your partners.

(FIVE MINUTES LATER...)

All right, then. Give us some disagreements.

- Even if we agree that abortion is morally wrong, it does not necessarily mean it should be illegal. Cheating on your boyfriend or girlfriend is morally wrong, but no one says you should go to jail if you do it, right? There are many moral questions that we don't ban, and so why should we ban this one?

Yeah, you can argue that that logic would take us to some dangerous places—kind of like a slippery slope. If we ban abortion for being immoral, then we should also ban all these other things which we think are immoral. If we think greed is immoral, should we ban being greedy, and so on.

You didn't think of an external there? I think that's quite easy—like, if we ban abortion, what harm might that cause? We might have many women who die thanks to failed pregnancies, right? Which causes health issues in the mother because she can't have an abortion. She herself might actually die. Again, kind of a slippery slope—people say, well, we wouldn't ban abortion for people with medical emergencies, but in reality, that does often actually happen. Doctors are too afraid to carry out the abortion.

I had a student in the Wednesday class who said, you know, if we ban abortion, then many criminals won't be born and this is good for society. But I feel like that's a bit of a callous-sounding (听起来冷酷无情) argument. Perhaps you could say many children would be born who would suffer, like they have medical conditions that will end their life very young, and yet they'd still be born, suffer for a few months, and then die.

And everyone would agree that eight months pregnancy is probably a human, and most people would agree that one day of pregnancy is probably not, but where do we cut off? Where do we put that line? If you hear this debate in America, one side says that is a human because it will be a human, and the other side says well it's not a human yet, so therefore it's not a human. It's very tricky to come down on one side, but yeah, you can come down on that side absolutely. It's just a cluster of cells, it cannot survive on its own and therefore does not meet the legal definition.

In fact, I think it's really a political issue in America. I can't think of many other countries where there's so much disagreement. You know, either countries are totally in favor of banning it or totally against banning it. I can't think of anywhere else that has this two-sided debate except America.

And if preventing these cells from becoming a human is wrong, then isn't preventing the pregnancy in the first place also wrong? Should we ban condoms, too, because they will stop cells becoming a human?

- Do you guys have anything? Yong?

Polygamous system can cause gender inequality——especially for women.

Of course, gender equality especially for women, yes. So yeah, often it would be young poor women marrying rich old men, and this would lead to a big gender disparity for improvement. Or you could go further with that—what happens if poor young girls marry rich old men? Then the poor young men are forced to be single, and what will they do? Maybe they will join terrorist groups or criminal gangs or destabilize society. This does actually happen in parts of Africa and the Middle East. There's a lot of polygamy, they have lots of angry young men.

And we should not allow something if people consent to it. So if you think about the examples I showed you, one of them is selling kidneys, right? Should we allow people to sell their kidneys? One of them is about prostitution—should we allow people to sell sex, right? These are similar examples to this.

And also, you could argue that can people really consent to a polygamous marriage? Because it's very clear-cut, right—if you have one person who wants to marry another person, you can ask them both, "Do you agree?" They can stand at the altar and say, "I do," right? But can four people stand at the altar and say, "I do, I do, I do, I do"? It's much more complicated whether you agree to the full arrangement of the marriage. And you're probably not going to get married four at a time, right—you're going to get married two people first, and then add another person later. And so did that person agree to add someone else later? It's not clear, right, so you could actually disagree with the consent there in the first place, I think.

There was a professor, I think he was at 浙江 University a few years ago, he argued that because China has too many men and not enough women, China should legalize polyandry, which is when one wife can have two husbands. And a lot of people were debating this, right, but it's true—there are something like 30 million men in China more than there are women. So how can they get married? Well, there's your solution—marry two of them to one woman. I don't think many men would want that, but I think he was maybe just provoking debate.

Have you heard of Pascal's wager, you know, the French mathematician Pascal? So he basically said that if you believe in God and God is not real, when you die, no problem, nothing bad, right? But if you don't believe in God and God *is* real, when you die, now you're in big trouble. So a rational person would just believe in God anyway because it's the safer thing to do. I think that's an interesting logical construction. Can anyone disagree with him?

Have you ever heard the idea of a false choice? Either go to college or become a 美团 driver. Maybe your parents would say to you, "If you don't study, you will deliver 美团," right, but actually there are many other things you could do instead of go to college or deliver 美团. And maybe there's a false choice here. Is it a choice between believing in God and not believing in God? Well, there are many Gods, right. What if I didn't believe in the Hindu God, right, so now I go to Hindu Hell because I didn't believe in Vishnu. Or the Muslim God, or the Jewish God, or—which God should I believe in? Should I believe in Zeus and Thor and Mars and Jupiter, right—like which God should I actually believe in here? And there's a kind of dichotomy there that isn't real. 😊 And if I just believe in God because I'm afraid of Hell, God knows this and he will punish me anyway because my belief wasn't truthful.

Anyway, that was just fun but interesting logic. After the break, what I'll ask you guys to do is each group discuss with each other and pick one of your second essays from that group. And then try to draw it up as a syllogism. So claim one, claim two, and the conclusion, and then each group will submit one syllogism. And then as a class we will try to disagree with your second essays. So start thinking about how you might model your second essay's logic.

11.3 Practice

All right, so group up—groups of three—and then we can get four groups, I guess, and talk to your partners about your topic. Pick one that you think is interesting or controversial, and then, you know, model it as a syllogism, right? So just make sure that the two claims link with each other. Don't do a logical progression where they're about different things, right—make sure they link up and have a logical conclusion, which would be your main idea. I'll put them up on the board and we can try to disagree with them. So do your syllogism first, I'll give you a few minutes to talk to each other.

(FIVE MINUTES LATER...)

Okay, start with you guys—give us one. Wait, don't read the essay. Just discuss it. What I mean is, you yourself can tell— all I mean is discuss the topic. You don't need to read the whole essay. I'm not expecting you guys to read essays just yet. What I mean is, Louise can tell you what her essay was about and how she would call its syllogism, and you can tell him, and you can tell you, and then pick the one you think is most interesting. Just a few more minutes. Okay, I'll give you three more minutes. I'm not expecting you to read the essay.

(THREE MINUTES LATER...)

- ① Prisons are for reform.
- ② Prisons can't reform.
- **Conclusion:** Abolish prisons, use high-tech alternatives to replace prison punishment.

For the internal logic, we already have more education and skill education for rehabilitation. And from the external logic, if we abolish the prisons, then the other principles of justice cannot be addressed, such as deterrence (威慑) and incapacitation, you know — public safety and so on. So even if it is right, there might be other costs as well. By the way, don't worry about having your essays critiqued here — there's nothing wrong with that, it doesn't mean you'll get a low grade for the feedback. So yeah, so prisons can't reform — you could definitely disagree with that and say maybe prisons don't reform, but that's because we're doing it wrong, and if we change something we could actually make prisons better. And if we abolish prisons, maybe we can reform people better — but what about deterring crimes, what about keeping society safe from criminals who should be locked away.

- ① Society over-educates people.
- ② The economy does not match education.
- **Conclusion:** Educated people forced into crime.

You're saying educating people is good. So in a way, you're disagreeing with the internal logic — you're saying that educated people wouldn't commit crimes, therefore even if they are not taken by a job, they probably wouldn't commit. It's an interesting one, isn't it? I think this has been talked about quite a lot in recent years. I think China's youth unemployment is getting higher than it used to be. One reason for that was that, you know, studying English or sociology or something like that isn't very useful for the modern job market where you need technical skills to match. Yeah. But it seems like they are addressing that now by cutting the number

of humanities majors and pushing people toward technology or to match with the requirements of the job market if you have any other discipline. That's kind of like a fact topic, so I guess you have to do internal disagreement — you can't really have outside that.

John Maynard Keynes' famous idea: poverty in the midst of plenty.

Overproduction is actually the reason why so many people, whether educated or not, are unemployed right now.

- ① People choose path of least resistance, like current.
- ② Phones are easier than books, more info.
- **Conclusion:** People always rely on their phones.

Yeah, I tend to agree that people do choose the easiest option usually, even if it's kind of against their own interests. The example I always think of is: people always complain when Walmart opens in their city and the local businesses all go out of business because Walmart is cheaper. People always say, "This is terrible and I think we shouldn't do it," but then when they go out shopping, they go to Walmart because they can save \$10 by shopping at Walmart and they don't care about their local consumers, right? So people always choose it even if they actually disagree with it — they often choose it themselves.

And yeah — phones, do you think they're easier than books? I have heard some people arguing that when you read a book on your phone, it's actually really difficult. Even things like audio books, you know, when you listen to the book instead. I tend to fall asleep when I start listening to an audio book, whereas if I'm reading the actual physical book — you know, even if I'm going to fall asleep I'll mark the page and close the book — but you know, I wake up halfway through an audio book and I can't remember where I finished, and it's really difficult to actually get through a book.

- ① Monitoring stops invasive species.
- ② Human cannot 100% monitor.
- **Conclusion:** We cannot stop invasive species.

It's interesting — my father's older brother, he moved to New Zealand, and he actually started his own company dealing with this. And he got to go around the wilderness of New Zealand and shoot these animals. I can't remember what they were called — W-bats or something — but it was like a European animal that had got into New Zealand, and his whole company's job was to kill animals, like poison them and trap them and shoot them. And this kind of thing — he made lots of money from the government. The government would spend a lot of money trying to stop it, but they could never eradicate the invasive species — there were just too many of them.

I did actually, interestingly, see a video about this a few days ago — there was a part of Canada, I think it's Alberta. They have kept rats out, and they are the only part of the whole world that doesn't have any rats. I don't know if that's true because, like I said, I saw it in a YouTube video and not an academic source, but it *can* be done according to the Canadian province of Alberta.

Did you draw any further conclusion from this? If we cannot stop invasive species, then — so we should cancel? We shouldn't try, we shouldn't spend money on companies like my uncle had, they shouldn't waste money on paying people to try and prevent invasive species. Is it a problem in China?

I saw an interesting article — there was a plan, I think as well in New Zealand, and the plan was to genetically engineer rats. Not that they couldn't reproduce, but their genetic — I forget the details — but their children couldn't reproduce. It was like a gene that they would pass to the next generation, and that would stop that generation from reproducing. And if they did it, it would destroy all rats in New Zealand in two generations.

And scientists were getting very worried about it because they said if even one rat got out of New Zealand into another country and passed on that gene, the whole world population of rats could be wiped out. It would cause huge damage to ecosystems. In Scotland we are having a debate about whether we should bring back wolves, you know, because wolves hunt certain animals and this could reduce certain species. Interesting topic.

All right, anyway — good, I think you get it with disagreement. So apply these skills to the third essay, to the example essay that you pick. And don't forget to hand it in next week — that's your final homework assignment.

We've still got almost 10 minutes, so due to the small class size we finished quite early. It might be worth mentioning briefly fallacies (谬论) — you guys know what I mean, fallacies. Like I mentioned earlier, we don't have time to go over a whole lesson on fallacies, but like I said, false choice is a fallacy — if someone says either go to college or drive Ola, you know, that's this kind of fallacy. Just quickly — can anyone think of other examples of fallacies? And we've studied this in the critical thinking class before as well.

Slippery slope fallacy — good. That can be a useful one, right. Like you can use that as an argument against someone like we did last week — he says that if we allow torture we will only use it to punish serious terrorists, but actually it could become much more common than that kind of thing. Good.

Straw man — yeah, be careful of the straw man fallacy. Does anyone know what that means? Straw man — when I say my idiot opponent has this stupid idea, and I make them look really silly. Yeah. The opposite of straw man is steel man, right, so try to make your opponent's arguments look as strong as possible and disagree with those. Yeah, don't deliberately make the author sound like their ideas are stupid, because I don't think they are. But yeah, I do sometimes see students doing that — they say "This author thinks that everyone should be a prostitute." No — that's not what they're saying, right? They're just saying that if we legalize prostitution then it will be less harmful. So don't mischaracterise the arguments of the author.

Circular reasoning. Yeah, when the claim and the reason for the claim are kind of the same thing — we call this circular reasoning. "This thing should be illegal." "Why?" "Well it's banned, so therefore it must be illegal." Or — the example I would often see in this class with the values claim — students would say "Fudan should abolish the 30% A rule because the 30% A rule is morally wrong," or something like that. But why is it morally wrong, what makes it morally wrong? They'll just state the reason again, that's a fallacy.

Emotional fallacy. Remember that one with teaching kids to kill — he says "Look at this poor mother who lost her daughter, and how terrible and how sad she is." Just appealing to emotion — because any parent who loses a child is a tragedy, but it doesn't mean that thing should be banned or not, right?

We appeal to many things besides emotion. Can you think of other things we appeal to? Well, it's fine to appeal to logic, but sometimes we appeal to things like history — "Britain has always had a royal family, therefore we must continue to have a royal family." Or we appeal to the majority — "Most people think this is good, therefore that thing must be good." Another example would be nature — "This thing is 100% natural. Nature is good. Therefore this thing must be good." But, you know, 100% natural snake venom — would you like some? You know — 100% natural poisonous mushrooms — would you like to try my 100% natural mushrooms that are full of deadly toxins? So we appeal to things which we assume are good, which might not necessarily be.

Anyway, like I said, we don't have time to get a PPT or anything on fallacies, but if you ask AI to give you some fallacy examples, that's probably fine. I think we can have an early lunch today, so feel free to go — and don't forget to bring your essay printed with you to class next week. And see — they were all happy about the early lunch, I think. Oh yeah — for the second essays, I'll try and get them back to you next week. You guys are my fourth writing class, so it's not a 100% guarantee — I will try my best, but it might not.

The End